Name of the Disease	Causative agent	Symptom	Incubation period
Fungal STI			
Candidiasis	*Candida albicans*	Attacks mouth, throat, intestinal tract and vagina. Vaginal itching or soreness, abnormal vaginal discharge and pain during urination.	–
Protozoan STI			
Trichomoniasis	*Trichomonas vaginalis*	Vaginitis , greenish yellow vaginal discharge, itching and burning sensation, urethritis, epididymitis and prostatitis	4-28 days

Cervical cancer

Cervical cancer is caused by a sexually transmitted virus called Human Papilloma virus (HPV). HPV may cause abnormal growth of cervical cells or cervical dysplasia.

The most common symptoms and signs of cervical cancer are pelvic pain, increased vaginal discharge and abnormal vaginal bleeding. The risk factors for cervical cancer include

1. Having multiple sexual partners
2. Prolonged use of contraceptive pills

Cervical cancer can be diagnosed by a Papanicolaou smear (PAP smear) combined with an HPV test. X-Ray, CT scan, MRI and a PET scan may also be used to determine the stage of cancer. The treatment options for cervical cancer include radiation therapy, surgery and chemotherapy.

Modern screening techniques can detect precancerous changes in the cervix. Therefore screening is recommended for women above 30 years once in a year. Cervical cancer can be prevented with vaccination. Primary prevention begins with HPV vaccination of girls aged 9 – 13 years, before they become sexually active. Modification in lifestyle can also help in preventing cervical cancer. Healthy diet, avoiding tobacco usage, preventing early marriages, practicing monogamy and regular exercise minimize the risk of cervical cancer.

3.7. Infertility

Inability to conceive or produce children even after unprotected sexual cohabitation is called infertility. That is, the inability of a man to produce sufficient numbers or quality of sperm to impregnate a woman or inability of a woman to become pregnant or maintain a pregnancy.

The causes for infertility are tumours formed in the pituitary or reproductive organs, inherited mutations of genes responsible for the biosynthesis of sex hormones, malformation of the cervix or fallopian tubes and inadequate nutrition before adulthood. Long-term stress damages many aspects of health especially the menstrual cycle. Ingestion of toxins (heavy metal cadmium), heavy use of alcohol, tobacco and marijuana, injuries to the gonads and aging also cause infertility.

Other causes of infertility

- Pelvic inflammatory disease (PID), uterine fibroids and endometriosis are the most common causes of infertility in women.
- Low body fat or anorexia in women. i.e. a psychiatric eating disorder characterised by the fear of gaining weight.
- Undescended testes and swollen veins (varicocoele) in scrotum.

TN_GOVT_XII_Bio_Zoology_EM_chapter 3.indd 38 20-03-2020 10.32.44 AM